

Find your first automation in 10 minutes

List every task you did more than once last week — small ones count (replying to leads, chasing an invoice, copying data between tools, posting content, sending recaps). Then run each task through these five questions.

1 Does it repeat on a schedule?

Daily or weekly beats monthly.

Frequency is what makes automation pay. A 15-minute task done daily is 90 hours a year.

score: daily +3 · weekly +2 · monthly +1

2 Are the steps the same every time?

Could you write the steps on one index card?

If yes, a machine can follow the card. If every instance is different, it's not automation material yet.

score: identical steps +3 · mostly same +2 · always different +0

3 Does it need your judgment — or just your hands?

The question that surprises people.

Most tasks founders "must do personally" only need their hands (moving, formatting, sending), not their judgment (deciding). Hands-work automates. Judgment-work gets a draft prepared for you instead.

score: just hands +3 · draft-then-approve +2 · pure judgment +0

4 Would you pay someone to never make you do it again?

The emotional test — it's rarely wrong.

The task you dread is the one you delay; the one you delay is the one that leaks money.

score: instantly yes +3 · probably +1

5 Does it touch money or leads?

Careful tier — automate the draft, keep the send.

Invoice chasing, lead replies, quotes: highest payoff AND highest risk. Automate everything up to the final tap, then you press send. One rule keeps it safe:

machines draft, you send.

score: yes +2 (and apply the rule) · no +1

Your first automation = the task scoring 10+. Tie-breaker: pick the one from question 4. **Not** the fanciest one. Not the newest AI toy. The boring 10+ task.

What to build it with

YOUR WINNER LOOKS LIKE...	START WITH
Same message answered again and again	Claude Project with your FAQ + tone → drafts replies, you send
Data moved between two tools	n8n or Zapier: trigger → transform → destination. No AI needed.
Chasing invoices / follow-ups	n8n schedule + Claude-drafted nudge emails, escalating politely

Weekly report or recap

Scheduled Claude job: pull numbers → 3 plain-English takeaways

Posting content everywhere

Make it once, schedule via a posting API (one render → all platforms)

The 2-week rule: run the automation alongside your manual process for two weeks before trusting it. If its drafts match what you would have done 9 times out of 10, hand it the keys (except the send button).

Kill one task this weekend. Then come back for the next one.

@shazimbuides – DM "AUTOMATE" questions any time